

« What makes Ashwin's career remarkable is how he consistently builds on his natural talent »»

Jayant Yadav

A decade ago, I met Ash for the first time in Chennai, thanks to Eric Simmons, who was then the bowling coach of the Delhi Daredevils (now Delhi Capitals). Eric connected us. Around that time, Ash was preparing for the England tour. I travelled to Chennai to meet him and to bowl alongside him.

He was incredibly kind and generous, taking the time to talk to me and train with me. It has been a long time since then, so I don't recall every detail of our conversation, but I vividly remember how generous he was in allowing someone to come all the way from Delhi to train with him.

By then, he was already an established Test bowler, and that gesture speaks volumes about his character. Throughout my stint in Chennai, I remember the warmth and genuineness he showed towards me. He always encouraged me, which left a lasting impression.

Who could have imagined that years later, we would end up as teammates in the national team? When playing in the Ranji Trophy, you often look at other contemporary spinners, especially off-spinners, who were quite rare at the time.

By then, Ash had already represented the country, and Bhajju pa (Harbhajan Singh) was nearing the end of his career. What stood out about Ash was not just his skill but his uniqueness, which I believe was unmatched. And I use the word 'unmatched' deliberately.

Many players have a natural, inherent ability to pick up the ball early and read its length quickly. What makes Ash's career remarkable is how he consistently builds on his natural talent. He would take what he had, refine it, and add to it over time, effectively 'banking' his skills and enhancing them throughout his journey.

Theoretically, every cricketer aspires to do this, but very few can achieve it. Ash's greatness lies in the fact that he consistently improved himself.

Every year or two, he would add something new to his game. This was not only a testament to his incredible skill but also to his mental toughness and determination.

Ash always sought to improve and excel, and that relentless drive to innovate is what set him apart.

**As told to
Shayan Acharya**

K. MURALI KUMAR

